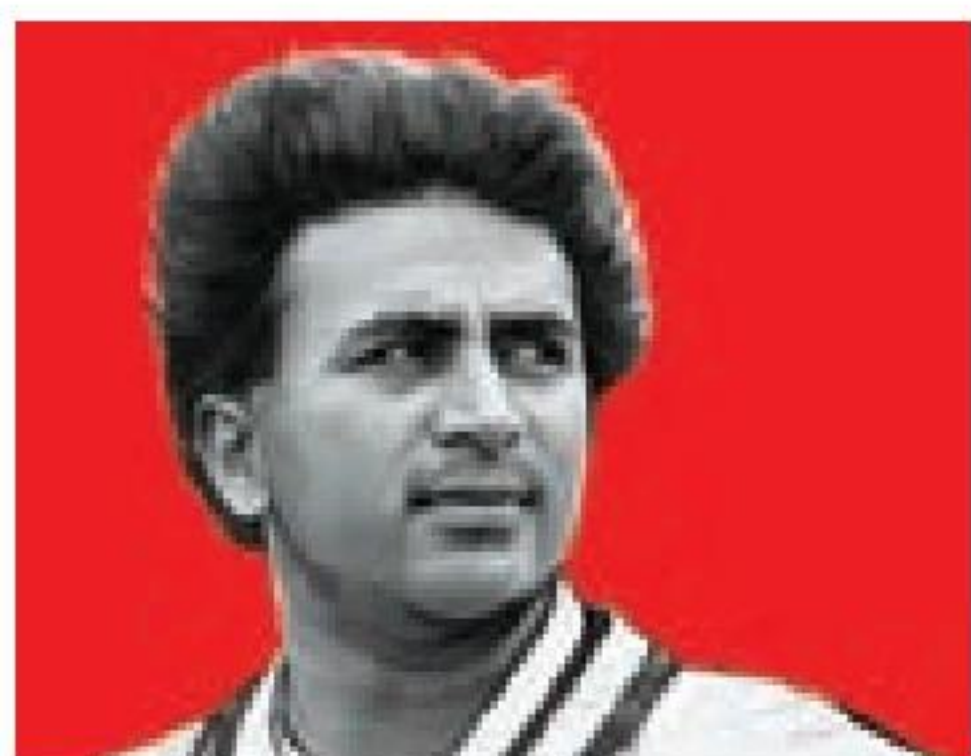




ON THE WRITE LINE

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TODAY'S CROWD LOVES A SHOWMAN

As Wimbledon begins, Alcaraz and Sinner's **rivalry** and respect signal a shift, not just in who dominates, but in how they do it.

The start of the Wimbledon tennis fortnight immediately brings to mind the epic men's singles final of the French Open played in June. It was a final between two players who could possibly dominate the world of tennis for the next decade or so. There are others, too, who on their day can take the trophies away from them, but the completeness of their game means that these two will be incredibly hard to beat. Even the Big Three — Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic — each had a surface they weren't fully comfortable on. If it was the clay at the French Open for Federer and, to a certain extent, Djokovic, too, it was the grass at Wimbledon where Nadal cracked more often than not. Even though it's early days, that doesn't seem to be the case with Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner, who seem equally at home on all the surfaces.

That final at the French Open last month stands out not just for the quality of tennis but also for the sportsmanship on display. In touch-and-go situations where every point could

well be the turning one, both were quick to indicate that some of the calls by the line judges were wrong and conceded the point to the other. In a time when it's fashionable to question every call, watching two young superstars in the making concede points that could have swung a Grand Slam final was truly heart-warming. Not to speak of losing a million dollars or so, if by conceding the point, they lost the match. May the example of these two wonderful players be adopted by other sportspersons too.

What that final also showed was that today's crowd loves a showman. So Alcaraz, the defending champion, was the crowd favourite because he would play to the gallery with his gestures.

Sinner, on the other hand, was the strong, silent type just going about his business, and apart from having a go once at his coaching staff in the box in the final set, he just went about his game, showing no emotion whatsoever. There was no throwing or smashing of racquets even after the heartbreaking loss.

If the French Open relied on the keen eye of